

Tai Motion

TAI CHI · GUIDE SERIES

Better Sleep

A calming Chair Tai Chi wind-down and simple habits to help you fall asleep more easily, sleep more deeply, and wake feeling rested.

Chair Tai Chi · Restful nights · No pills

Welcome to your Sleep guide

A good night's sleep touches everything — your energy, your mood, your balance, your memory, even your appetite. When you sleep well, the whole day feels kinder.

If sleep has become lighter or more broken over the years, you are far from alone. The good news is that small, gentle changes to your evenings and your habits can make a real difference — no pills required.

This guide gives you a calming seven-step wind-down routine built around gentle **Chair Tai Chi**, then simple ideas for your bedroom, your days, and those nights when sleep won't come. Take what helps and leave the rest.

Why Tai Chi helps you sleep. Slow, flowing Tai Chi movement paired with easy breathing calms the nervous system and quiets a busy mind. It's one of the most studied gentle practices for better sleep in older adults — which is why an evening Chair Tai Chi flow sits at the heart of this routine.

A quick note before you begin. This is general wellness guidance, not medical advice. Ongoing sleep problems can have treatable medical causes. If poor sleep troubles you most nights, or you notice loud snoring, gasping, or strong daytime sleepiness, please see your doctor.

How sleep changes after 50

Understanding what's normal can take away a lot of worry — and worry itself is one of sleep's biggest enemies.

Lighter, earlier sleep is common

With age, we often spend more time in lighter sleep and less in deep sleep, so we wake more easily. Many people also feel sleepy earlier in the evening and wake earlier in the morning. This is a normal shift, not a fault.

You may need a little less

Most older adults still need around 7–8 hours, but some feel fine on a bit less. What matters most is how *rested* you feel during the day, not the exact number on the clock.

Small disruptions add up

Aches, a fuller bladder, medications, caffeine, worry and warm rooms can all nibble at sleep. The habits in this guide — with gentle Tai Chi to unwind body and mind — are designed to gently protect against them.

The kindest mindset: aim for restful, not perfect. One broken night is nothing to fear — chasing sleep too hard tends to push it further away.

Dim the Lights

Good for gently telling your body that sleep is on its way.



1. About an hour before bed, turn off bright overhead lights.
2. Switch to soft, warm lamps or a low side light.
3. Keep the mood cosy and calm as the evening winds down.

Try tonight: Lower the lighting an hour before bed.

Bright light tells your brain it's still daytime — softening it helps sleepiness arrive naturally.

Bedtime Chair Tai Chi

Good for melting away the day's tension with slow, flowing movement.



1. Sit tall and relaxed, both hands resting low in your lap with palms turned up (photo 1).
2. Breathe in and slowly float both open palms upward to about chest height, soft and flowing (photo 2).
3. Breathe out and let your hands sink gently back down. Repeat slowly, with your breath, 6–8 times.

Try tonight: A few minutes of slow, flowing Chair Tai Chi.

Move with your breath, not the clock — slow and graceful is the whole point. This gentle flow is the heart of your wind-down.

A Warm, Soothing Drink

Good for a calming ritual that says the day is done.



1. Make a warm, caffeine-free drink — chamomile, warm milk or herbal tea.
2. Sip it slowly, somewhere comfortable, without rushing.
3. Let the warmth and the pause soothe you.

Try tonight: A caffeine-free warm drink, sipped slowly.

The ritual matters as much as the drink — a gentle signal that it's time to slow down.

Unplug from Screens

Good for quieting a busy mind and protecting your natural sleepiness.



1. Set the television, tablet and phone aside 30–60 min before bed.
2. Swap the screen for a paper book, gentle music or quiet company.
3. If you use a phone as a clock, turn it face-down.

Try tonight: Screens away 30–60 minutes before bed.

Screen light and busy news can keep the mind wound up — a calm, offline hour helps you drift off.

Slow 4-7-8 Breathing

Good for calming your nervous system so sleep can come.



1. Sitting or lying comfortably, breathe in gently through your nose for a count of 4.
2. Softly hold for 7 (or a shorter count that feels easy).
3. Breathe out slowly through your mouth for 8. Repeat 3-4 times.

Try tonight: A few rounds of slow 4-7-8 breaths.

This breath-with-stillness is pure Tai Chi — a longer out-breath gently switches on your body's “rest” mode.

Write It Down

Good for emptying a worried mind onto the page.



1. Keep a small notebook by your chair or bed.
2. Jot down anything on your mind, or tomorrow's little to-dos.
3. Add one good thing from your day — a moment of gratitude.

Try tonight: A two-minute brain-dump before bed.

Putting worries and tasks on paper tells your mind it can safely let them go for the night.

Settle & Relax Your Body

Good for letting go of tension so you drift off comfortably.



1. Once in bed, take a slow, easy breath and let your shoulders sink.
2. Working from your feet upward, gently relax each part of your body.
3. Let your face, jaw and hands soften completely.

Try tonight: Relax your body part by part, feet to face.

Releasing tension bit by bit quietly guides your body from awake into restful sleep.

Your sleep-friendly bedroom



Your bedroom sets the stage for sleep — a few simple touches make it easier to drift off and stay asleep. Leave a little space by a comfy chair, too, for your evening Chair Tai Chi.

- ✓ **Cool** — a slightly cool room (around 18°C / 65°F) suits sleep best.
- ✓ **Dark** — use curtains or a soft eye mask; cover bright standby lights.
- ✓ **Quiet** — earplugs or a low, steady sound can mask disturbances.
- ✓ **Comfortable** — a supportive mattress and pillow make a real difference to achy joints.
- ✓ **For sleep, not screens** — keep the television and phone out where you can.
- ✓ **Easy underfoot** — a clear path and a dim, warm night-light for night-time trips (kinder to sleep than a bright overhead, and safer than the dark).

Daytime habits that help you sleep

Good nights are built during the day. These gentle habits set your body clock for easier sleep.

Keep a steady rhythm

Try to wake and rise at about the same time every day, even after a poor night. A regular wake-time is the single strongest anchor for your body clock.

Catch the morning light

Get some natural daylight soon after waking — by a window or, better still, outdoors. Morning light helps you feel alert by day and sleepy at night.

Move gently and often

A little activity — a walk, your Chair Tai Chi, some stretching — helps you sleep more deeply. A daytime Tai Chi session also makes your evening wind-down feel even more natural. Aim to finish any vigorous movement a few hours before bed.

Mind the caffeine

Keep tea, coffee and cola to the morning. Caffeine can linger for 8 hours or more and quietly disturb sleep.

Keep naps short and early

If you nap, keep it to 20–30 minutes and before mid-afternoon, so it doesn't borrow from your night.

Eat & drink for better sleep

What and when you eat in the evening can help — or hinder — a restful night.

Gently helps

A light, balanced supper. A small bedtime snack if you're hungry — warm milk, a little yogurt, a banana, or a few oats. Herbal teas like chamomile.

Best limited at night

Caffeine (tea, coffee, cola, dark chocolate). Large, heavy or spicy meals close to bed. Alcohol — it may make you drowsy but leads to broken, lighter sleep. Lots of fluid right before bed, to save night-time trips.

A gentle rhythm: aim to finish your main meal 2–3 hours before bed, so digestion is settled by the time your head hits the pillow.

When you wake in the night

Waking in the night is normal — it's what happens next that matters. Staying calm is the key.

Don't watch the clock

Checking the time feeds worry and wakes you further. Turn the clock away and trust that rest will come.

Stay calm and breathe

Keep the lights low and try your slow 4-7-8 breathing or the body-relaxation from your wind-down routine. Often you'll drift back off.

If you're still awake after ~20 minutes

Rather than lying there frustrated, get up, keep the lights dim, and do something quiet — a little reading, or a few slow, seated Tai Chi arm movements — until you feel sleepy, then return to bed.

Be kind to yourself

One restless night won't harm you. Reassuring yourself gently is far more helpful than fighting to fall asleep.

A gentle evening timeline

An example of how the pieces fit together. Adjust the times to suit your own evening.

2-3 hrs before bed	Finish your main meal; switch to caffeine-free drinks.
1 hr before bed	Dim the lights and start to slow down with a little Chair Tai Chi.
30-60 min before	Screens away. A warm drink, a book, quiet company.
15 min before	Write down any worries or to-dos. A few slow breaths.
In bed	Relax your body part by part and let sleep come.
Next morning	Rise at a steady time and catch some daylight.

Remember: the exact times don't matter. What helps is the gentle, repeated signal to your body that the day is ending.

When to talk to your doctor

Sometimes poor sleep has a medical cause that's very treatable. It's worth a conversation with your doctor if you notice:

- ✓ Loud snoring, gasping, or pauses in breathing during sleep.
 - ✓ Strong daytime sleepiness that affects your day or driving.
 - ✓ Trouble falling or staying asleep most nights for several weeks.
 - ✓ Uncomfortable, restless legs that keep you awake.
 - ✓ Sleep that worsened after starting a new medication.
 - ✓ Low mood, anxiety, or pain that disturbs your nights.
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Please don't start or stop any sleep medication on your own. Talk with your doctor or pharmacist — some interact with other medicines, and there are gentle, effective options worth discussing.

This guide is part of the Tai Motion Tai Chi Guide Series. It offers general wellness suggestions only and is not medical advice. It is not intended to diagnose, treat, cure, or prevent any condition. Always talk to a qualified healthcare professional about ongoing sleep problems or before changing any medication. © Tai Motion.